

# 23 Reuben

*Jacob's firstborn, a man of good intentions who lost his place through one grave sin.*

Reuben was the eldest of Jacob's twelve sons, born to Leah in Haran. As firstborn he should have led the family. He often meant well. He tried to rescue Joseph from his brothers, spoke up about their guilt, and offered his own sons as a pledge for Benjamin's safety. But he also committed a grave sin against his father, and at Jacob's deathbed he heard the words "Unstable as water, thou shalt not excel." The firstborn's rights passed to Joseph's sons, and leadership to Judah. His life shows that good intentions matter, but so do steady faithfulness and self-control.

## At a glance

|               |                                                      |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Hebrew <i>Re'uven</i> , "See, a son" (Genesis 29:32) |
| Family        | Firstborn of Jacob and Leah                          |
| Sons          | Hanoch, Phallu, Hezron and Carmi (Genesis 46:9)      |
| Key places    | Haran; Canaan; Dothan; Egypt                         |
| Key people    | Jacob, Leah, Joseph, Benjamin, Bilhah                |
| Main passages | Genesis 35:22; 37:21–30; 42:22, 37; 49:3–4           |
| His tribe     | Settled east of the Jordan (Numbers 32:1–33)         |
| New Testament | The tribe of Reuben in Revelation 7:5                |

*"And Reuben said unto them, Shed no blood, but cast him into this pit that is in the wilderness, and lay no hand upon him; that he might rid him out of their hands, to deliver him to his father again."*

Genesis 37:22, KJV

# The life of Reuben

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Reuben. The order below follows the text. He was born early in Jacob's twenty years in Haran (Genesis 29:32; 31:41).

|                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| In Haran                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Jacob's firstborn</b><br/>Leah bears her first son. She names him Reuben, saying, "Surely the LORD hath looked upon my affliction; now therefore my husband will love me."<br/><i>Genesis 29:31-32</i></li></ul> |
| Wheat harvest            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Brings mandrakes</b><br/>Young Reuben finds mandrakes in the field and brings them to his mother. Leah and Rachel bargain over them.<br/><i>Genesis 30:14-16</i></li></ul>                                       |
| Beyond the tower of Edar | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Sins against his father</b><br/>After Rachel's death, Reuben sleeps with Bilhah, his father's concubine. Genesis says only, "and Israel heard it."<br/><i>Genesis 35:21-22</i></li></ul>                         |
| At Dothan                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Tries to save Joseph</b><br/>The brothers plot to kill Joseph. Reuben talks them into throwing him into a pit instead, planning to rescue him. He returns to find Joseph gone. <i>Genesis 37:18-30</i></li></ul> |
| In Egypt                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Names the brothers' guilt</b><br/>When the governor of Egypt treats them harshly, Reuben reminds his brothers that he had warned them not to sin against the boy. <i>Genesis 42:21-24</i></li></ul>              |
| Back in Canaan           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Offers his sons</b><br/>Jacob refuses to send Benjamin to Egypt. Reuben says, "Slay my two sons, if I bring him not to thee." Jacob still refuses. <i>Genesis 42:35-38</i></li></ul>                             |
| Jacob's deathbed         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● <b>Loses the firstborn's place</b><br/>Jacob calls him "my might, and the beginning of my strength," but says he will not excel, because he defiled his father's bed. <i>Genesis 49:3-4</i></li></ul>               |

# Key activities

*Some readers see Reuben's sin with Bilhah as lust. Others think he meant to stop Bilhah, Rachel's maid, from taking Rachel's place above his mother Leah, or to claim leadership early. Genesis gives no motive.*

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- 1 Brought a gift to his mother.** He found mandrakes in the wheat harvest and gave them to Leah. *Genesis 30:14*
  - 2 Dishonored his father.** He slept with Bilhah, his father's concubine, and Jacob heard of it. *Genesis 35:22*
  - 3 Stopped a murder.** He said, "Let us not kill him," and persuaded his brothers to use the pit instead. *Genesis 37:21-22*
  - 4 Grieved for Joseph.** Finding the pit empty, he tore his clothes and cried, "The child is not; and I, whither shall I go?" *Genesis 37:29-30*
  - 5 Spoke up about guilt.** In Egypt he said, "Spake I not unto you, saying, Do not sin against the child; and ye would not hear?" *Genesis 42:22*
  - 6 Offered a costly pledge.** He offered his own two sons as surety for Benjamin's safe return. *Genesis 42:37*
  - 7 Went down to Egypt.** He moved to Egypt with his four sons and all Jacob's family. *Genesis 46:8-9*
  - 8 Received Jacob's hard word.** He heard that he was "Unstable as water" and would not excel. *Genesis 49:3-4*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Reuben.

## Old Testament

|                      |                                                |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Genesis 29:32–49:4   | The main account of his life                   |
| Genesis 48:5         | Joseph's sons adopted "as Reuben and Simeon"   |
| 1 Chronicles 5:1–2   | His birthright "given unto the sons of Joseph" |
| Numbers 32:1–33      | His tribe settles east of the Jordan           |
| Deuteronomy 33:6     | "Let Reuben live, and not die"                 |
| Judges 5:15–16       | "Great searchings of heart" in Reuben          |
| Echo: Proverbs 16:32 | "He that ruleth his spirit"                    |

## New Testament

|                 |                                                    |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Revelation 7:5  | Reuben among the sealed tribes, second after Judah |
| Echo: James 1:8 | "Unstable in all his ways"                         |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Reuben plan to do for Joseph (Genesis 37:22), and what happened instead?
2. *Understand:* Reuben meant well, yet is remembered as "unstable." What was missing?
3. *Apply:* Where do you need to speak up now rather than wait?
4. *Apply:* Reuben's tribe was still blessed (Deuteronomy 33:6). How does God's mercy give you hope after failure?